

All For All

Kropotkin

Peter (Pyotr Alexeyevich) Kropotkin (1842-1921)

Published: 1892 - As 'The Conquest Of Bread'

Revised: 2026 - BASE Infobase Zine Version

With our minds already narrowed in our youth, enslaved by the past in our mature age and till the grave, we hardly dare to think. If a new idea is mentioned — before venturing on an opinion of our own, we consult musty books a hundred years old, to know what ancient masters thought on the subject. ...⁴²

Inspired by a new daring — thanks to the sentiment of solidarity — all will march together to the conquest of the high joys of knowledge and artistic creation.

A society thus inspired will fear neither dissensions within nor enemies without. To the coalitions of the past it will oppose a new harmony, the initiative of each and all, the daring which springs from the awakening of a people's genius.

Before such an irresistible force 'conspiring kings' will be powerless. Nothing will remain for them but to bow before it, and to harness themselves to the chariot of humanity, rolling towards new horizons opened up by the Social Revolution.

- *Q: What does Kropotkin believe will give the social revolution its decisive strength?*

This was an abridgement of the first three chapters of The Conquest Of Bread (and a few paragraphs at the end from its conclusion), chapters 4-17 cover practical applications of these principles, addressing food, housing, clothing, agriculture, technology, labour, and the organisation of a free society based on mutual aid and voluntary cooperation.

⁴²Passage removed for conciseness.

To-day, when groups scattered far and wide wish to organise themselves for some object or other, they no longer elect an international parliament of Jacks-of-all-trades. No, where it is not possible to meet directly or come to an agreement by correspondence, delegates versed in the question at issue are sent to treat, with the instructions: 'Endeavour to come to an agreement on such or such a question and then return not with a law in your pocket, but with a proposition of agreement which we may or may not accept.'

Such is the method of the great industrial companies, the learned societies, and the associations of every description, which already cover Europe and the United States. And such should be the method of an emancipated society. While bringing about expropriation, society cannot continue to organise itself on the principle of parliamentary representation. A society founded on serfdom is in keeping with absolute monarchy; a society based on the wage system and the exploitation of the masses by the capitalists finds its political expression in parliamentarianism. But a free society, regaining possession of the common inheritance, must seek, in free groups and free federations of groups, a new organisation, in harmony with the new economic phase of history.

Every economic phase has a political phase corresponding to it, and it would be impossible to touch property without finding at the same time a new mode of political life.

- *Q: What examples does Kropotkin give of voluntary cooperation already replacing government, and what does this suggest about the future?*

III - Bringing About the Revolution Together

Solidarity and collective initiative are what the revolution most needs. A people united in common labour become an irresistible force, before which the old powers cannot stand.

The only thing that may be wanting to the Revolution is the boldness of initiative.

OUR RICHES

I - The Progress of Human Civilisation

Society has developed exponentially through agriculture and industry, creating enough wealth and productive capacity to improve everyone's well-being.

The human race has travelled a long way, since those remote ages when men fashioned their rude implements of flint and lived on the precarious spoils of hunting, leaving to their children for their only heritage a shelter beneath the rocks, some poor utensils—and Nature, vast, unknown, and terrific, with whom they had to fight for their wretched existence.

During the long succession of agitated ages which have elapsed since, mankind has nevertheless amassed untold treasures. It has cleared the land, dried the marshes, hewn down forests, made roads, pierced mountains; it has been building, inventing, observing, reasoning; it has created a complex machinery, wrested her secrets from Nature, and finally it pressed steam and electricity into its service.¹ And the result is, that now the child of the civilised man finds at its birth, ready for its use, an immense capital accumulated by those who have gone before him.² And this capital enables man to acquire, merely by his own labour combined with the labour of others, riches surpassing the dreams of the fairy tales of the *Thousand and One Nights*.³

The soil is cleared to a great extent, fit for the reception of the best seeds, ready to give a rich return for the skill and labour spent upon

¹The use of steam power and electricity marked major technological advancements during the Industrial Revolution of the 18th and 19th centuries, transforming manufacturing, transportation, and daily life.

²An economic system where the means of production (factories, land, tools) are privately owned, and goods are produced for profit through wage labour. Emerged in its modern form in the 18th-19th centuries.

³Also known as 'Arabian Nights,' this is a collection of Middle Eastern folk tales compiled during the Islamic Golden Age (8th-13th centuries). It was widely popular in Europe following its translation in the early 18th century.

it—a return more than sufficient for all the wants of humanity. The methods of rational cultivation are known.

On the wide prairies of America each hundred men, with the aid of powerful machinery, can produce in a few months enough wheat to maintain 10,000 people for a whole year. And where man wishes to double his produce, to treble it, to multiply it a hundredfold, he makes the soil, gives to each plant the requisite care, and thus obtains enormous returns. While the hunter of old had to scour fifty or sixty square miles to find food for his family, the civilised man supports his household, with far less pains, and far more certainty, on a thousandth part of that space. Climate is no longer an obstacle. When the sun fails, man replaces it by artificial heat; and we see the coming of a time when artificial light also will be used to stimulate vegetation. Meanwhile, by the use of glass and hot water pipes, man renders a given space ten and fifty times more productive than it was in its natural state.

The prodigies accomplished in industry are still more striking. With the cooperation of those intelligent beings, modern machines—themselves the fruit of three or four generations of inventors, mostly unknown—a hundred men manufacture now the stuff to provide 10,000 persons with clothing for two years. In well-managed coal mines the labour of a hundred miners furnishes each year enough fuel to warm 10,000 families under an inclement sky. And we have lately witnessed the spectacle of wonderful cities springing up in a few months for international exhibitions⁴, without interrupting in the slightest degree the regular work of the nations.

And if in manufactures as in agriculture, and as indeed through our whole social system, the labour, the discoveries, and the inventions of our ancestors profit chiefly the few, it is none the less certain that mankind in general, aided by the creatures of steel and iron which it already possesses, could already procure an existence of wealth and ease for every one of its members.

⁴This likely refers to World's Fairs or Universal Expositions, popular in the 19th and early 20th centuries. These large international exhibitions showcased cultural and technological achievements, often featuring specially constructed pavilions and even entire 'exhibition cities'.

These organisations, free and infinitely varied, are so natural an outcome of our civilisation; they expand so rapidly and group themselves with so much ease; they are so necessary a result of the continual growth of the needs of civilised man; and lastly, they so advantageously replace governmental interference that we must recognise in them a factor of growing importance in the life of societies. If they do not yet spread over the whole of the manifestations of life, it is that they find an insurmountable obstacle in the poverty of the worker, in the casts of present society, in the private appropriation of capital, and in the State. Abolish these obstacles and you will see them covering the immense field of civilised man's activity.

The history of the last fifty years furnishes a living proof that Representative Government is impotent to discharge the functions we have sought to assign to it. In days to come the nineteenth century will be quoted as having witnessed the failure of parliamentarianism.

But this impotence is becoming evident to all; the faults of parliamentarianism, and the inherent vices of the representative principle, are self-evident, and the few thinkers who have made a critical study of them (J. S. Mill and Leverdays)⁴⁰ did but give literary form to the popular dissatisfaction. It is not difficult, indeed, to see the absurdity of naming a few men and saying to them, 'Make laws regulating all our spheres of activity, although not one of you knows anything about them!'

We are beginning to see that government by majorities means abandoning all the affairs of the country to the tide-waiters who make up the majorities in the House and in election committees;⁴¹ to those, in a word, who have no opinion of their own. But mankind is seeking and already finding new issues.

The International Postal Union, the railway unions, and the learned societies give us examples of solutions based on free agreement in place and stead of law.

⁴⁰John Stuart Mill (1806–1873), English philosopher and political economist, and Émile Leverdays (1835–1890), French writer — both critics of parliamentary government from different traditions.

⁴¹Tide-Waiters are customs officers who waited on the tide for incoming ships. Here referring to opportunists who go whichever way the current flows.

the result of the need felt by each one of us to seek the support, the co-operation, the sympathy of his neighbours.

Assuredly the idea of a society without a State will give rise to at least as many objections as the political economy of a society without private capital. We have all been brought up from our childhood to regard the State as a sort of Providence;³⁸ all our education, the Roman history we learned at school, the Byzantine code which we studied later under the name of Roman law, and the various sciences taught at the universities, accustom us to believe in Government and in the virtues of the State providential.

To maintain this superstition whole systems of philosophy have been elaborated and taught; all politics are based on this principle; and each politician, whatever his colours, comes forward and says to the people, 'Give me the power, and I both can and will free you from the miseries which press so heavily upon you.'

From the cradle to the grave all our actions are guided by this principle. Open any book on sociology or jurisprudence, and you will find there the Government, its organisation, its acts, filling so large a place that we come to believe that there is nothing outside the Government and the world of statesmen.

The press teaches us the same in every conceivable way. Whole columns are devoted to parliamentary debates and to political intrigues. The vast every day life of a nation is barely mentioned in a few lines when dealing with economic subjects, law, or in 'divers (various) facts' relating to police cases. And when you read these newspapers, you hardly think of the incalculable number of beings — all humanity, so to say — who grow up and die, who know sorrow, who work and consume, think and create outside the few encumbering personages who have been so magnified that humanity is hidden by their shadows enlarged by our ignorance.

And yet as soon as we pass from printed matter, to life itself, as soon as we throw a glance at society, we are struck by the infinitesimal part played by the Government. ...³⁹

Truly, we are rich—far richer than we think; rich in what we already possess, richer still in the possibilities of production of our actual mechanical outfit; richest of all in what we might win from our soil, from our manufactures, from our science, from our technical knowledge, were they but applied to bringing about the well-being of all.

- *Q: How has human progress since prehistoric times expanded our ability to produce wealth and resources?*

II - The Paradox of Wealth and Poverty

Poverty persists despite abundant resources because a minority controls production and prioritises profit over society's well-being.

In our civilised societies we are rich. Why then are the many poor? Why this painful drudgery for the masses? Why, even to the best paid workman, this uncertainty for the morrow, in the midst of all the wealth inherited from the past, and in spite of the powerful means of production, which could ensure comfort to all, in return for a few hours of daily toil?

The Socialists have said it and repeated it unwearingly. Daily they reiterate it, demonstrating it by arguments taken from all the sciences. It is because all that is necessary for production—the land, the mines, the highways, machinery, food, shelter, education, knowledge—all have been seized by the few in the course of that long story of robbery, enforced migration and wars, of ignorance and oppression, which has been the life of the human race before it had learned to subdue the forces of Nature. It is because, taking advantage of alleged rights acquired in the past, these few appropriate today two-thirds of the products of human labour, and then squander them in the most stupid and shameful way. It is because, having reduced the masses to a point at which they have not the means of subsistence for a month, or even for a week in advance, the few can allow the many to work, only on the condition of themselves receiving the lion's share. It is because these few prevent the remainder of men from producing the things they need, and force them to produce, not the necessities of life for all, but

³⁸The idea that God or fate guides human affairs.

³⁹Passage removed for conciseness.

whatever offers the greatest profits to the monopolists. In this is the substance of all Socialism.⁵

Take, indeed, a civilised country. The forests which once covered it have been cleared, the marshes drained, the climate improved. It has been made habitable. The soil, which bore formerly only a coarse vegetation, is covered today with rich harvests. The rock-walls in the valleys are laid out in terraces and covered with vines. The wild plants, which yielded nought but acrid berries, or uneatable roots, have been transformed by generations of culture into succulent vegetables or trees covered with delicious fruits. Thousands of highways and railroads furrow the earth, and pierce the mountains. The shriek of the engine is heard in the wild gorges of the Alps, the Caucasus, and the Himalayas. The rivers have been made navigable; the coasts, carefully surveyed, are easy of access; artificial harbours, laboriously dug out and protected against the fury of the sea, afford shelter to the ships. Deep shafts have been sunk in the rocks; labyrinths of underground galleries have been dug out where coal may be raised or minerals extracted. At the crossings of the highways great cities have sprung up, and within their borders all the treasures of industry, science, and art have been accumulated.

- *Q: Why does poverty persist despite the abundance of wealth and resources in society?*

The Historical Accumulation of Wealth

Modern infrastructure is due to the accumulated labour of countless generations who often suffered under oppressive conditions, with today's wealth still owing its origins to this system.

Whole generations, that lived and died in misery, oppressed and ill-treated by their masters, and worn out by toil, have handed on this immense inheritance to our century. For thousands of years millions of men have laboured to clear the forests, to drain the marshes, and to

⁵A broad political and economic tradition advocating collective or social ownership of the means of production, and producing for need instead of profit.

progress both in the economic and the intellectual field. Now it is the enfranchisement of the communes, whose monuments, produced by the free labour of the guilds, have never been surpassed; now it is the peasant rising which brought about the Reformation and imperilled the papacy;³⁷ and then again it is the society, free for a brief space, which was created at the other side of the Atlantic by the malcontents from the Old World.

Further, if we observe the present development of civilised peoples we see, most unmistakably, a movement ever more and more marked to limit the sphere of action of the Government, and to allow more and more liberty to the individual. This evolution is going on before our eyes, though cumbered by the ruins and rubbish of old institutions and old superstitions. Like all evolutions, it only waits a revolution to overthrow the old obstacles which block the way, that it may find free scope in a regenerated society.

After having striven long in vain to solve the insoluble problem — the problem of constructing a government ‘which will constrain the individual to obedience without itself ceasing to be the servant of society,’ men at last attempt to free themselves from every form of government and to satisfy their need for organisation by a free contract between individuals and groups pursuing the same aim. The independence of each small territorial unit becomes a pressing need; mutual agreement replaces law, and everywhere regulates individual interests in view of a common object.

All that was once looked on as a function of the Government is to-day called in question. Things are arranged more easily and more satisfactorily without the intervention of the State. And in studying the progress made in this direction, we are led to conclude that the tendency of the human race is to reduce Government interference to zero; in fact, to abolish the State, the personification of injustice, oppression, and monopoly.

We can already catch glimpses of a world in which the bonds which bind the individual are no longer laws, but social habits —

³⁷The 16th-century religious upheaval beginning with Martin Luther's challenge to the Catholic Church in 1517.

How can we doubt, then, that when the instruments of production are placed at the service of all, when business is conducted on Communist principles, when labour, having recovered its place of honour in society, produces much more than is necessary to all — how can we doubt but that this force (already so powerful) will enlarge its sphere of action till it becomes the ruling principle of social life?

Following these indications, and considering further the practical side of expropriation, of which we shall speak in the following chapters, we are convinced that our first obligation, when the revolution shall have broken the power upholding the present system, will be to realise Communism without delay.

But ours is neither the rigid planning of utopian reformers, nor the centralised control of state bureaucracies.³⁶ It is Anarchist Communism — Communism without government — the Communism of the Free. It is the synthesis of the two ideals pursued by humanity throughout the ages — Economic and Political Liberty.

- *Q: Why should we reject paying workers in proportion to the hours they labour, even under a socialist system?*

II - A Society Without The State

History shows humanity progressing by limiting the State's reach. Free agreement between groups already replaces law in trade, science, and communication — pointing toward the possibility of a society organised through federation rather than government.

In taking 'Anarchy' for our ideal of political organisation we are only giving expression to another marked tendency of human progress. Whenever European societies have developed up to a certain point they have shaken off the yoke of authority and substituted a system founded roughly more or less on the principles of individual liberty. And history shows us that these periods of partial or general revolution, when the governments were overthrown, were also periods of sudden

open up highways by land and water. Every rood (quarter acre) of soil we cultivate in Europe has been watered by the sweat of several races of men. Every acre has its story of enforced labour, of intolerable toil, of the people's sufferings. Every mile of railway, every yard of tunnel, has received its share of human blood.

The shafts of the mine still bear on their rocky walls the marks made by the pick of the workman who toiled to excavate them. The space between each prop in the underground galleries might be marked as a miner's grave; and who can tell what each of these graves has cost, in tears, in privations, in unspeakable wretchedness to the family who depended on the scanty wage of the worker cut off in his prime by firedamp, rockfall, or flood?⁶

The cities, bound together by railroads and waterways, are organisms which have lived through centuries. Dig beneath them and you find, one above another, the foundations of streets, of houses, of theatres, of public buildings. Search into their history and you will see how the civilisation of the town, its industry, its special characteristics, have slowly grown and ripened through the cooperation of generations of its inhabitants before it could become what it is today. And even today, the value of each dwelling, factory, and warehouse, which has been created by the accumulated labour of the millions of workers, now dead and buried, is only maintained by the very presence and labour of legions of the men who now inhabit that special corner of the globe. Each of the atoms composing what we call the Wealth of Nations owes its value to the fact that it is a part of the great whole. What would a London dockyard or a great Paris warehouse be if they were not situated in these great centres of international commerce? What would become of our mines, our factories, our workshops, and our railways, without the immense quantities of merchandise transported every day by sea and land?

- *Q: How have past generations contributed to the wealth and infrastructure of the modern world?*

³⁶Modernised text.

⁶Methane gas that accumulates in coal mines and can ignite explosively.

The Collective Nature of Progress and Innovation

Every innovation builds upon accumulated knowledge from countless unnamed contributors throughout history, making true individual ownership of ideas impossible.

Millions of human beings have laboured to create this civilisation on which we pride ourselves today. Other millions, scattered through the globe, labour to maintain it. Without them nothing would be left in fifty years but ruins. **There is not even a thought, or an invention, which is not common property, born of the past and the present.** Thousands of inventors, known and unknown, who have died in poverty, have cooperated in the invention of each of these machines which embody the genius of man.

Thousands of writers, of poets, of scholars, have laboured to increase knowledge, to dissipate error, and to create that atmosphere of scientific thought, without which the marvels of our century could never have appeared. And these thousands of philosophers, of poets, of scholars, of inventors, have themselves been supported by the labour of past centuries. They have been upheld and nourished through life, both physically and mentally, by legions of workers and craftsmen of all sorts. They have drawn their motive force from the environment.

The genius of a Séguin, a Mayer, a Grove,⁷ has certainly done more to launch industry in new directions than all the capitalists in the world. But men of genius are themselves the children of industry as well as of science. Not until thousands of steam-engines had been working for years before all eyes, constantly transforming heat into dynamic force, and this force into sound, light, and electricity, could the insight of genius proclaim the mechanical origin and the unity of the physical forces. And if we, children of the nineteenth century, have at last grasped this idea, if we know now how to apply it, it is again because daily experience has prepared the way. The thinkers of the eighteenth century saw and

its gardens, its library, its laboratories, and its annual conversaziones to each of its members³⁴, whether he be a Darwin, or a simple amateur.

*In well-equipped public workshops and shared facilities, if you are pursuing an invention, you can access tools and technical equipment, provided only you know how to use them; and you are allowed to work there as long as you please.*³⁵ There are the tools; interest others in your idea, join with fellow workers skilled in various crafts, or work alone if you prefer it. Invent a flying machine, or invent nothing — that is your own affair. You are pursuing an idea — that is enough.

In the same way, those who man the lifeboat do not ask credentials from the crew of a sinking ship; they launch their boat, risk their lives in the raging waves, and sometimes perish, all to save men whom they do not even know. And what need to know them? They are human beings, and they need our aid — that is enough, that establishes their right — To the rescue!

Thus we find a tendency, eminently communistic, springing up on all sides, and in various guises, in the very heart of theoretically individualist societies.'

Suppose that one of our great cities, so egotistic in ordinary times, were visited to-morrow by some calamity — a siege, for instance — that same selfish city would decide that the first needs to satisfy were those of the children and the aged. Without asking what services they had rendered, or were likely to render to society, it would first of all feed them. Then the combatants would be cared for, irrespective of the courage or the intelligence which each has displayed, and thousands of men and women would outvie (outdo) each other in unselfish devotion to the wounded.

This tendency exists and is felt as soon as the most pressing needs of each are satisfied, and in proportion as the productive power of the race increases. It becomes an active force every time a great idea comes to oust the mean preoccupations of everyday life.

⁷Marc Séguin (1786-1875) was a French engineer known for inventing the wire-cable suspension bridge and improving the steam engine. Julius Robert von Mayer (1814-1878) was a German physician and physicist who was one of the founders of thermodynamics. Sir William Robert Grove (1811-1896) was a Welsh judge and physical scientist who anticipated the general theory of the conservation of energy and invented the Grove fuel cell.

³⁴Scholarly social gatherings, common in 19th-century learned societies, where members met to discuss ideas, share research, and view collections.

³⁵Modernised text.

given to men's minds by the commercial system, the tendency towards Communism is constantly appearing, and influences our activities in a variety of ways.

The bridges, for the use of which a toll was levied in the old days, are now become public property and free to all; so are the high roads, except in the East, where a toll is still exacted from the traveller for every mile of his journey. Museums, free libraries, free schools, free meals for children; parks and gardens open to all; streets paved and lighted, free to all; water supplied to every house without measure or stint — all such arrangements are founded on the principle: 'Take what you need.'

The tramways and railways have already introduced monthly and annual season tickets, without limiting the number of journeys taken; *and some transport systems have introduced flat-rate travel passes, which permit the holder to travel unlimited distances for the same price.*³³ It is but a short step from that to a uniform charge, such as already prevails in the postal service. In all these innovations, and a thousand others, the tendency is not to measure the individual consumption. One man wants to travel a thousand miles, another five hundred. These are personal requirements. There is no sufficient reason why one should pay twice as much as the other because his need is twice as great. Such are the signs which appear even now in our individualist societies.

Moreover, there is a tendency, though still a feeble one, to consider the needs of the individual, irrespective of his past or possible services to the community. We are beginning to think of society as a whole, each part of which is so intimately bound up with the others that a service rendered to one is a service rendered to all.

When you go into a public library — not indeed the National Library of Paris, but, say, into the British Museum or the Berlin Library — the librarian does not ask what services you have rendered to society before giving you the book, or the fifty books which you require, and he comes to your assistance if you do not know how to manage the catalogue. By means of uniform credentials — and very often a contribution of work is preferred — the scientific society opens its museums,

declared it, but the idea remained undeveloped, because the eighteenth century had not grown up like ours, side by side with the steam-engine. Imagine the decades that might have passed while we remained in ignorance of this law, which has revolutionised modern industry, had Watt⁸ not found at Soho skilled workmen to embody his ideas in metal, bringing all the parts of his engine to perfection, so that steam, pent in a complete mechanism, and rendered more docile than a horse, more manageable than water, became at last the very soul of modern industry.

Every machine has had the same history—a long record of sleepless nights and of poverty, of disillusion and of joys, of partial improvements discovered by several generations of nameless workers, who have added to the original invention these little nothings, without which the most fertile idea would remain fruitless. More than that: every new invention is a synthesis, the resultant of innumerable inventions which have preceded it in the vast field of mechanics and industry.

Science and industry, knowledge and application, discovery and practical realisation leading to new discoveries, cunning of brain and of hand, toil of mind and muscle—all work together. Each discovery, each advance, each increase in the sum of human riches, owes its being to the physical and mental travail of the past and the present. By what right then can anyone whatever appropriate the least morsel of this immense whole and say—This is mine, not yours?

- *Q: How does the world depend on the collective efforts of past and present generations?*

III - The Monopolisation of Resources

A wealthy minority has seized the control of resources created through collective labour, forcing workers to surrender much of their output to owners.

⁸James Watt (1736-1819) was a Scottish inventor who significantly improved the steam engine, making it more efficient and adaptable for industrial use. Soho refers to the Soho Foundry in Birmingham, England, where Watt and his business partner Matthew Boulton manufactured steam engines.

³³Modernised text.

It has come about, however, in the course of the ages traversed by the human race, that all that enables man to produce and to increase his power of production has been seized by the few. Some time, perhaps, we will relate how this came to pass. For the present let it suffice to state the fact and analyse its consequences.

Today the soil, which actually owes its value to the needs of an ever-increasing population, belongs to a minority who prevent the people from cultivating it—or do not allow them to cultivate it according to modern methods.

The mines, though they represent the labour of several generations, and derive their sole value from the requirements of the industry of a nation and the density of the population—the mines also belong to the few; and these few restrict the output of coal, or prevent it entirely, if they find more profitable investments for their capital. Machinery, too, has become the exclusive property of the few, and even when a machine incontestably represents the improvements added to the original rough invention by three or four generations of workers, it none the less belongs to a few owners. And if the descendants of the very inventor who constructed the first machine for lace-making⁹, a century ago, were to present themselves today in a lace factory at Bâle or Nottingham, and claim their rights, they would be told: ‘Hands off! this machine is not yours,’ and they would be shot down if they attempted to take possession of it.

The railways, which would be useless as so much old iron without the teeming population of Europe, its industry, its commerce, and its marts, belong to a few shareholders, ignorant perhaps of the whereabouts of the lines of rails which yield them revenues greater than those of medieval kings. And if the children of those who perished by thousands while excavating the railway cuttings and tunnels were to assemble one day, crowding in their rags and hunger, to demand bread

⁹The lace-making machine, likely referring to the bobbin net machine invented by John Heathcoat in 1808 or the Leavers machine developed by John Leavers in 1813, revolutionised the lace industry. Nottingham, England, and Basel, Switzerland, were significant centres of lace production in the 19th century.

the attempt to disguise it as ‘profit-sharing.’ **The common possession of the instruments of labour must necessarily bring with it the enjoyment in common of the fruits of common labour.**

We hold further that Communism is not only desirable, but that existing societies, founded on Individualism, are inevitably impelled in the direction of Communism. The development of Individualism during the last three centuries is explained by the efforts of the individual to protect himself from the tyranny of Capital and of the State. For a time he imagined, and those who expressed his thought for him declared, that he could free himself entirely from the State and from society. ‘By means of money,’ he said, ‘I can buy all that I need.’ But the individual was on a wrong tack, and modern history has taught him to recognise that, without the help of all, he can do nothing, although his strong-boxes are full of gold.

In fact, alongside this current of Individualism, we find in all modern history a tendency, on the one hand, to retain all that remains of the partial Communism of antiquity, and, on the other, to establish the Communist principle in the thousand developments of modern life.

As soon as the communes of the tenth, eleventh, and twelfth centuries had succeeded in emancipating themselves from their lords, ecclesiastical or lay, their communal labour and communal consumption began to extend and develop rapidly. The township — and not private persons — freighted ships and equipped expeditions, and the benefit arising from the foreign trade did not accrue to individuals, but was shared by all. The townships also bought provisions for their citizens. Traces of these institutions have lingered on into the nineteenth century, and the folk piously cherish the memory of them in their legends.

All that has disappeared. But the rural township still struggles to preserve the last traces of this Communism, and it succeeds — except when the State throws its heavy sword into the balance.

Meanwhile new organisations, based on the same principle — to every man according to his needs — spring up under a thousand different forms; for without a certain leaven of Communism the present societies could not exist. In spite of the narrowly egoistic turn

of culture reached by the working classes as a whole, to the labours, in short, of men in every corner of the globe.

*The migrant workers who die on massive infrastructure projects, the seafarers lost at sea, and the factory workers who succumb to industrial diseases have all helped develop the modern global economy, along with the exhausted workers in manufacturing hubs and the innovators who (following the suggestion of some worker) succeed in improving production methods.*³¹

How, then, shall we estimate the share of each in the riches which ALL contribute to amass?

Looking at production from this general, synthetic point of view, we cannot hold with the Collectivists that payment proportionate to the hours of labour rendered by each would be an ideal arrangement, or even a step in the right direction.

Without discussing whether exchange value of goods is really measured in existing societies by the amount of work necessary to produce it — according to the doctrine of Smith and Ricardo³², in whose footsteps Marx has followed — suffice it to say here, leaving ourselves free to return to the subject later, that the Collectivist ideal appears to us untenable in a society which considers the instruments of labour as a common inheritance. Starting from this principle, such a society would find itself forced from the very outset to abandon all forms of wages.

The mitigated individualism of the collectivist system certainly could not maintain itself alongside a partial communism — the socialisation of land and the instruments of production. A new form of property requires a new form of remuneration. A new method of production cannot exist side by side with the old forms of consumption, any more than it can adapt itself to the old forms of political organisation.

The wage system arises out of the individual ownership of the land and the instruments of labour. It was the necessary condition for the development of capitalist production, and will perish with it, in spite of

from the shareholders, they would be met with bayonets and grapeshot, to disperse them and safeguard ‘vested interests.’

In virtue of this monstrous system, the son of the worker, on entering life, finds no field which he may till, no machine which he may tend, no mine in which he may dig, without accepting to leave a great part of what he will produce to a master. He must sell his labour for a scant and uncertain wage. His father and his grandfather have toiled to drain this field, to build this mill, to perfect this machine. They gave to the work the full measure of their strength, and what more could they give? But their heir comes into the world poorer than the lowest savage. If he obtains leave to till the fields, it is on condition of surrendering a quarter of the produce to his master, and another quarter to the government and the middlemen. And this tax, levied upon him by the State, the capitalist, the lord of the manor, and the middleman, is always increasing; it rarely leaves him the power to improve his system of culture. If he turns to industry, he is allowed to work—though not always even that—only on condition that he yield a half or two-thirds of the product to him whom the land recognizes as the owner of the machine.

We cry shame on the feudal baron who forbade the peasant to turn a clod of earth unless he surrendered to his lord a fourth of his crop. We called those the barbarous times. But if the forms have changed, the relations have remained the same, and the worker is forced, under the name of free contract, to accept feudal obligations. For, turn where he will, he can find no better conditions. Everything has become private property, and he must accept, or die of hunger.

- *Q: How does private ownership of productive resources affect workers?*

The Consequences of Capitalist Production

Our profit-driven economic system creates market instability and global conflicts while perpetuating inequality and requiring repressive control.

The result of this state of things is that all our production tends in a wrong direction. Enterprise takes no thought for the needs of the com-

³¹Modernised text.

³²Adam Smith (1723–1790) and David Ricardo (1772–1823), foundational figures of classical economics who developed the labour theory of value later adopted and transformed by Marx.

munity. Its only aim is to increase the gains of the speculator. Hence the constant fluctuations of trade, the periodical industrial crises, each of which throws scores of thousands of workers on the streets.¹⁰

The working people cannot purchase with their wages the wealth which they have produced, and industry seeks foreign markets among the monied classes of other nations. In the East, in Africa, everywhere, in Egypt, Tonkin or the Congo¹¹, the European is thus bound to promote the growth of serfdom.¹² And so he does. But soon he finds that everywhere there are similar competitors. All the nations evolve on the same lines, and wars, perpetual wars, break out for the right of precedence in the market. Wars for the possession of the East, wars for the empire of the sea, wars to impose duties on imports and to dictate conditions to neighbouring states; wars against those 'blacks' who revolt! The roar of the cannon never ceases in the world, whole races are massacred, the states of Europe spend a third of their budgets in armaments; and we know how heavily these taxes fall on the workers.

Education still remains the privilege of a small minority, for it is idle to talk of education when the workman's child is forced, at the age of thirteen, to go down into the mine or to help his father on the farm. It is idle to talk of studying to the worker, who comes home in the evening wearied by excessive toil, and its brutalising atmosphere. Society is thus bound to remain divided into two hostile camps, and in such conditions freedom is a vain word. The Radical¹³ begins by demanding a greater extension of political rights, but he soon sees that the breath of liberty leads to the uplifting of the proletariat, and then he

¹⁰Referring to the boom-and-bust recession cycles common in capitalism, that cause widespread unemployment and hardship.

¹¹This passage refers to European colonial expansion in the late 19th century. Tonkin was the northern region of Vietnam under French colonial rule, while Congo likely refers to the Congo Free State, privately owned by King Leopold II of Belgium. The author is critiquing the exploitative nature of colonialism.

¹²This refers to the feudal system prevalent in medieval Europe, where peasants (serfs) were bound to work on a lord's land and pay taxes or tribute from their harvest. This system began to decline in Western Europe from the 14th century onward.

¹³Here, 'Radical' refers to political reformers who initially advocate for democratic rights but often revert to conservative positions when faced with the prospect of genuine social change.

ANARCHIST COMMUNISM

I - From Each, To All

Modern production is so interconnected that no individual contribution can be isolated or measured — making wage-based payment untenable. Communism is not just desirable, society is already preparing for it through libraries, parks, free schools, and shared infrastructure.

Every society which has abolished private property will be forced, we maintain, to organise itself on the lines of Communistic Anarchy.³⁰ Anarchy leads to Communism, and Communism to Anarchy, both alike being expressions of the predominant tendency in modern societies, the pursuit of equality.

Time was when a peasant family could consider the corn which it grew, or the woollen garments woven in the cottage, as the products of its own toil. But even then this way of looking at things was not quite correct. There were the roads and the bridges made in common, the swamps drained by common toil, and the communal pastures enclosed by hedges which were kept in repair by each and all. If the looms for weaving or the dyes for colouring fabrics were improved, all profited; so even in those days a peasant family could not live alone, but was dependent in a thousand ways on the village or the commune.

But nowadays, in the present state of industry, when everything is interdependent, when each branch of production is knit up with all the rest, the attempt to claim an Individualist origin for the products of industry is absolutely untenable. The astonishing perfection attained by the textile or mining industries in civilised countries is due to the simultaneous development of a thousand other industries, great and small, to the extension of the railroad system, to inter-oceanic navigation, to the manual skill of thousands of workers, to a certain standard

³⁰A political philosophy and society organised through voluntary cooperation and free association, without hierarchical authority. Not chaos, but order without domination.

- *Q: What is the difference between the 'right to work' and the 'right to well-being,' and why should we reject the former?*

turns round, changes his opinions, and reverts to repressive legislation and government by the sword.

A vast array of courts, judges, executioners, policemen, and jailers¹⁴ is needed to uphold these privileges; and this array gives rise in its turn to a whole system of espionage, of false witness, of spies, of threats and corruption.

The system under which we live checks in its turn the growth of the social sentiment. We all know that without uprightness, without self-respect, without sympathy and mutual aid, human kind must perish, as perish the few races of animals living by rapine, or the slave-keeping ants. But such ideas are not to the taste of the ruling classes, and they have elaborated a whole system of pseudoscience to teach the contrary.

Fine sermons have been preached on the text that those who have should share with those who have not, but he who would carry out this principle would be speedily informed that these beautiful sentiments are all very well in poetry, but not in practice.¹⁵ 'To lie is to degrade and besmirch oneself,' we say, and yet all civilised life becomes one huge lie. We accustom ourselves and our children to hypocrisy, to the practice of a double-faced morality. And since the brain is ill at ease among lies, we cheat ourselves with sophistry.¹⁶ Hypocrisy and sophistry become the second nature of the civilised man.

But a society cannot live thus; it must return to truth, or cease to exist.

- *Q: What are some of the negative consequences to society of a profit-driven economic system?*

¹⁴Orig. gaolers.

¹⁵ An allusion to Christian teachings on charity and sharing wealth, referencing Luke 3:11, and pointing out the hypocrisy of those who preach such ideals but do not practice them in reality.

¹⁶Sophistry refers to the use of clever but false arguments, especially with the intention of deceiving.

The Call for Communal Ownership

The dominance of monopolies in society necessitates returning to collective ownership of production and embracing 'All things for all' since everyone contributes to the global wealth and should benefit fairly from it.

Thus the consequences which spring from the original act of monopoly spread through the whole of social life. Under pain of death, human societies are forced to return to first principles: the means of production being the collective work of humanity, the product should be the collective property of the race. Individual appropriation is neither just nor serviceable. All belongs to all. All things are for all men, since all men have need of them, since all men have worked in the measure of their strength to produce them, and since it is not possible to evaluate everyone's part in the production of the world's wealth.

All things for all. Here is an immense stock of tools and implements; here are all those iron slaves which we call machines, which saw and plane, spin and weave for us, unmaking and remaking, working up raw matter to produce the marvels of our time. But nobody has the right to seize a single one of these machines and say: 'This is mine; if you want to use it you must pay me a tax on each of your products,' any more than the feudal lord of medieval times had the right to say to the peasant: 'This hill, this meadow belong to me, and you must pay me a tax on every sheaf of corn you reap, on every brick you build.'

All is for all! If the man and the woman bear their fair share of work, they have a right to their fair share of all that is produced by all, and that share is enough to secure them well-being. No more of such vague formulas as 'The right to work', or 'To each the whole result of his labour.' What we proclaim is The Right to Well-Being: Well-Being for All!

- *Q: How should we meet people's needs instead of the current system of private ownership?*

Let us have the courage to recognise that well-being for all, henceforward possible, must be realised.

*When workers demand meaningful employment today, they are offered minimum wage jobs or precarious public works projects, earning barely enough to survive! When they ask for better organisation of labour and decent working conditions, the response is always: 'Patience, friends, reforms are coming; meanwhile here's your subsistence wages. Be grateful for these crumbs from the table!'*²⁹ Meantime the cannons were trained, the reserves called out, and the workers themselves disorganised by the many methods well known to the middle classes, till one fine day they were told to go and colonise Africa or be shot down.

Very different will be the result if the workers claim the right to well-being! In claiming that right they claim the right to possess the wealth of the community — to take the houses to dwell in, according to the needs of each family; to seize the stores of food and learn the meaning of plenty, after having known famine too well. They proclaim their right to all wealth — fruit of the labour of past and present generations — and learn by its means to enjoy those higher pleasures of art and science too long monopolised by the middle classes.

And while asserting their right to live in comfort, they assert, what is still more important, their right to decide for themselves what this comfort shall be, what must be produced to ensure it, and what discarded as no longer of value.

The 'right to well-being' means the possibility of living like human beings, and of bringing up children to be members of a society better than ours, whilst the 'right to work' only means the right to be always a wage-slave, a drudge, ruled over and exploited by the middle class of the future. The right to well-being is the Social Revolution, the right to work means nothing but the Treadmill of Commercialism. **It is high time for the worker to assert his right to the common inheritance and to enter into possession.**

²⁹Modernised text.

- *Q: Why is overthrowing a government only the beginning, not the substance, of revolution?*

III - The Right to Live

The first act of revolution must be to guarantee everyone's right to live — taking immediate, practical possession of food, housing, and the means of well-being, rather than waiting for laws to grant rights.

It seems to us that there is only one answer to this question: We must recognise, and loudly proclaim, that **every one, whatever his grade in the old society, whether strong or weak, capable or incapable, has, before everything, THE RIGHT TO LIVE, and that society is bound to share amongst all, without exception, the means of existence at its disposal.** We must acknowledge this, and proclaim it aloud, and act up to it.

It must be so contrived that from the first day of the revolution the worker shall know that a new era is opening before him; that henceforward none need crouch under the bridges, with palaces hard by, none need fast in the midst of food, none need perish with cold near shops full of furs; that all is for all, in practice as well as in theory, and that at last, for the first time in history, a revolution has been accomplished which considers the **NEEDS** of the people before schooling them in their **DUTIES**.

This cannot be brought about by Acts of Parliament, but only by taking immediate and effective possession of all that is necessary to ensure the well-being of all; this is the only really scientific way of going to work, the only way to be understood and desired by the mass of the people. We must take possession, in the name of the people, of the granaries, the shops full of clothing, and the dwelling houses. Nothing must be wasted. We must organise without delay to feed the hungry, to satisfy all wants, to meet all needs, to produce, not for the special benefit of this one or that one, but to ensure that society as a whole will live and grow.

Enough of ambiguous words like 'the right to work,' with which the people were misled in 1848, and which are still used to mislead them.

WELL-BEING FOR ALL

I - The Possibility of Abundance

Society already produces enough for universal well-being, but production is artificially restricted by capital and squandered on the idle rich, making expropriation the necessary path forward.

Well-being for all is not a dream. It is possible, realisable, owing to all that our ancestors have done to increase our powers of production.

We know, indeed, that the producers, although they constitute hardly one-third of the inhabitants of civilised countries, even now produce such quantities of goods that a certain degree of comfort could be brought to every hearth. We know further that if all those who squander to-day the fruits of others' toil were forced to employ their leisure in useful work, our wealth would increase in proportion to the number of producers, and more. Finally, we know that contrary to the theory enunciated by Malthus¹⁷ — that Oracle of middle-class Economics — the productive powers of the human race increase at a much more rapid ratio than its powers of reproduction. The more thickly men are crowded on the soil, the more rapid is the growth of their wealth-creating power.

Thus, while populations in developed nations have grown steadily over recent decades, their productive capacity has increased at a far greater rate. Even in nations with modest population growth, industrial output and agricultural yields have multiplied many times over. In the most technologically advanced countries, this progress is even more striking. Despite – or rather because of – the movement of workers across borders, these nations have experienced exponential growth in their wealth-generating capabilities. This remarkable increase in productive efficiency has

¹⁷Thomas Malthus (1766-1834), English economist who argued population growth would outstrip food supply, used historically to justify policies against poor relief.

*occurred despite various obstacles: agricultural uncertainties, government interventions, military obligations, and the speculative nature of modern finance and commerce.*¹⁸

However, these figures give yet a very faint idea of what our wealth might become under better conditions. For alongside of the rapid development of our wealth-producing powers we have an overwhelming increase in the ranks of the idlers and middlemen. Instead of capital gradually concentrating itself in a few hands, so that it would only be necessary for the community to dispossess a few millionaires and enter upon its lawful heritage — instead of this Socialist forecast proving true, the exact reverse is coming to pass: the swarm of parasites is ever increasing.

*In today's industrialised nations, the proportion of actual producers in the population remains surprisingly small. Consider that the entire agricultural output of a developed nation typically relies on just a small percentage of its total workforce. Even in major industrial sectors like manufacturing and resource extraction, the number of actual producers represents only a fraction of the total population. But what of those who profit from this labour? The stark reality is that the genuine creators of exported goods – the actual producers of the wealth that flows to all corners of the globe – constitute only a small portion of the population. Meanwhile, a vast network of shareholders, intermediaries, and financial operators extract value at every step, positioning themselves between producer and consumer. These middlemen often capture the majority of the final price, leaving those who actually create the goods with a mere fraction of the value they produce. Through this system, they accumulate enormous unearned gains while contributing nothing to actual production.*¹⁹

Nor is this all. Those who withhold capital constantly reduce the output by restraining production. We need not speak of the cartloads of oysters thrown into the sea to prevent a dainty (delicacy), hitherto reserved for the rich, from becoming a food for the people. We need not speak of the thousand and one luxuries — stuffs, foods, etc. etc. —

places of safety. The people remain. This is how a revolution is ushered in. In several large towns the Commune is proclaimed. In the streets wander thousands of men, who in the evening crowd into improvised clubs asking: 'What shall we do?' and ardently discuss public affairs, in which all take an interest; those who yesterday were most indifferent are perhaps the most zealous. Everywhere there is plenty of goodwill and a keen desire to make victory certain. It is a time of supreme devotion. The people are ready to go forward.

All this is splendid, sublime; but still, it is not a revolution. Nay, it is only now that the work of the revolutionist begins.

*Doubtless personal scores will be settled. Unpopular officials and oppressive managers will face consequences for their actions, but that is only an incident of the struggle and not a revolution.*²⁵ ...²⁶

The people suffer. With the childlike faith, with the good humour of the masses who believe in their leaders, they think that 'yonder,' in the House, in the Town Hall, in the Committee of Public Safety, their welfare is being considered. But 'yonder' they are discussing everything under the sun except the welfare of the people. *While hunger spreads and threatens to derail real change, while people are reduced to the depths of misery, while the wealthy districts still showcase luxury cars and expensive fashions, the political elite debate abstract constitutional theories. While workers suffer from economic collapse, the new governments waste time arguing over administrative minutiae and bureaucratic reforms, without addressing how people are to survive the crisis.*²⁷ Any revolutionary movement that fails to understand that people cannot fight for change on an empty stomach, that families cannot survive on promises alone, is doomed to failure.²⁸

The people suffer and say: 'How to find the way out of these difficulties?'

²⁵ Modernised text.

²⁶ Passage removed for conciseness

²⁷ Modernised text.

²⁸ Modernised text.

¹⁸ Modernised text.

¹⁹ Modernised text.

necessity of a social revolution; rich and poor alike recognise that this revolution is imminent, that it may break out in a very few years.

A great change in thought has been accomplished during the last half of the nineteenth century; but suppressed, as it was, by the propertied classes, and denied its natural development, this new spirit must break now its bonds by violence and realise itself in a revolution.

Whence comes the revolution, and how will it announce its coming? None can answer these questions. The future is hidden. But those who watch and think do not misinterpret the signs: workers and exploiters, Revolutionists and Conservatives, thinkers and men of action, all feel that the revolution is at our doors.

Well! What are we to do when the thunderbolt has fallen?

We have all been studying the dramatic side of revolution so much, and the practical work of revolution so little, that we are apt to see only the stage effects, so to speak, of these great movements; the fight of the first days; the barricades. But this fight, this first skirmish, is soon ended, and it is only after the overthrow of the old constitution that the real work of revolution can be said to begin.

Effete and powerless, attacked on all sides, the old rulers are soon swept away by the breath of insurrection. *Time and again we have seen how swiftly the trappings of power can crumble – governments that appeared unshakeable one day vanish the next, leaving cities and peoples suddenly masters of their own destinies. Yet these were only insurrections, mere glimpses of what concerted action might achieve.*²⁴ Before a popular revolution the masters of ‘the old order’ disappear with a surprising rapidity. Its upholders fly the country, to plot in safety elsewhere and to devise measures for their return.

The former Government having disappeared, the army, hesitating before the tide of popular opinion, no longer obeys its commanders, who have also prudently decamped. The troops stand by without interfering, or join the rebels. The police, standing at ease, are uncertain whether to belabour the crowd or to cry: ‘Long live the Commune!’ while some retire to their quarters ‘to await the pleasure of the new Government.’ Wealthy citizens pack their trunks and betake themselves to

treated after the same fashion as the oysters. It is enough to remember the way in which the production of the most necessary things is limited. *Factories and production facilities regularly operate below capacity or temporarily shut down, while others force their workers into part-time or zero-hour contracts. Throughout the developed world, millions of people desperately seek stable, full-time employment but instead face a perpetual cycle of temporary work, uncertain hours, and enforced idleness. The tragic irony remains: there is plenty of work that needs doing, plenty of people willing to do it, and plenty of people in need of the goods and services that could be produced – yet the system prevents this natural connection between human needs and human capabilities.*²⁰

How gladly would these millions of men set to work to reclaim waste lands, or to transform ill-cultivated land into fertile fields, rich in harvests! A year of well-directed toil would suffice to multiply fivefold the produce of dry lands in the south of France which now yield only about eight bushels of wheat per acre. But these men, who would be happy to become hardy pioneers in so many branches of wealth-producing activity, must stay their hands because the owners of the soil, the mines, and the factories prefer to invest their capital — stolen in the first place from the community — in Turkish or Egyptian bonds, or in Patagonian gold mines, and so make Egyptian fellahs, Italian exiles, and Chinese coolies their wage-slaves.²¹

So much for the direct and deliberate limitation of production; but there is also a limitation indirect and not of set purpose, which consists in spending human toil on objects absolutely useless, or destined only to satisfy the dull vanity of the rich.

It is impossible to reckon in figures the extent to which wealth is restricted indirectly, the extent to which energy is squandered, that might have served to produce, and above all to prepare the machinery necessary to production. It is enough to cite the immense sums spent by Europe in armaments for the sole purpose of acquiring control of the markets, and so forcing her own commercial standards on neighbouring territories and making exploitation easier at home; the millions

²⁰Modernised text.

²¹Fellahin are Egyptian peasants, Coolie is a slur for South Asian labourers.

²⁴Modernised text.

paid every year to officials of all sorts, whose function it is to maintain the rights of minorities — the right, that is, of a few rich men — to manipulate the economic activities of the nation; the millions spent on judges, prisons, policemen, and all the paraphernalia of so-called justice — spent to no purpose, because we know that every alleviation, however slight, of the wretchedness of our great cities is followed by a very considerable diminution of crime; lastly, the millions spent on propagating pernicious doctrines by means of the press, and news ‘cooked’ in the interest of this or that party, of this politician or of that company of exploiters.

But over and above this we must take into account all the labour that goes to sheer waste, in keeping up the stables, the kennels, and the retinue of the rich, for instance; in pandering to the caprices of society and to the depraved tastes of the fashionable mob; in forcing the consumer on the one hand to buy what he does not need, or foisting an inferior article upon him by means of puffery, and in producing on the other hand wares which are absolutely injurious, but profitable to the manufacturer. What is squandered in this manner would be enough to double our real wealth, or so to plenish (stock) our mills and factories with machinery that they would soon flood the shops with all that is now lacking to two-thirds of the nation. Under our present system a full quarter of the producers in every nation are forced to be idle for three or four months in the year, and the labour of another quarter, if not of the half, has no better results than the amusement of the rich or the exploitation of the public.

Thus, if we consider on the one hand the rapidity with which civilised nations augment their powers of production, and on the other hand the limits set to that production, be it directly or indirectly, by existing conditions, one cannot but conclude that an economic system a trifle more enlightened would permit them to heap up in a few years so many useful products that they would be constrained to cry — ‘Enough! We have enough coal and bread and raiment! Let us rest and consider how best to use our powers, how best to employ our leisure.’

No, plenty for all is not a dream — though it was a dream indeed in those old days when man, for all his pains, could hardly win a bushel of

wheat from an acre of land, and had to fashion by hand all the implements he used in agriculture and industry. Now it is no longer a dream, because man has invented a motor which, with a little iron and a few pounds of coal, gives him the mastery of a creature strong and docile as a horse, and capable of setting the most complicated machinery in motion.

But, if plenty for all is to become a reality, this immense capital — cities, houses, pastures, arable lands, factories, highways, education — must cease to be regarded as private property, for the monopolist to dispose of at his pleasure.

This rich endowment, painfully won, builded, fashioned, or invented by our ancestors, must become common property, so that the collective interests of men may gain from it the greatest good for all.

There must be EXPROPRIATION.²² The well-being of all — the end; expropriation — the means.

- *Q: Why is poverty an artificial condition rather than a natural one — and what must change to end poverty?*

II - Expropriation and Revolution

Political revolution alone is not enough — merely replacing one government with another leaves the people hungry while officials debate. Real revolution must address material needs from day one.

Expropriation, such then is the problem which history has put before the men of the twentieth century: the return to Communism²³ in all that ministers to the well-being of man.

But this problem cannot be solved by means of legislation. No one imagines that. The poor, no less than the rich, understand that neither the existing Governments, nor any which might arise out of possible political changes, would be capable of finding a solution. We feel the

²²The taking back of property which was once commonly available to all — particularly land, factories, and resources — from private owners to be held in common again.

²³A society organised around common ownership, without classes, state or money.